

Materialism: wrap-up

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1. Rebutting the argument from the or-to-if inference

An analogy with the epistemic modal ‘must’.

The following arguments have a ring of validity, no?

It’s either raining or snowing
But it’s not raining
So, it must be snowing

All men are mortal
Socrates is a man
So, Socrates must be mortal

What’s going on here...?

<this bit of the handout will be filled in later>

2. Another family of arguments for materialism: from embeddings

Another strategy for arguing for materialism looks at certain complex sentences that embed indicative conditionals, e.g. conjunctions of indicative conditionals. In some cases, these seem to have the weak truth conditions that materialism would predict.

- (1) If the die landed on an odd number it landed on 1 or 3, and if it landed on an even number it landed on 2
- Seems equivalent to ‘The die landed on 1 or 2 or 3’. If turns out it landed on 1, we don’t say ‘OK, so the first conjunct was true, but what about the second conjunct’?¹

3. A warning

We have already seen ample reason to think that there is lots of context-sensitivity in conditionals. It is a completely live option to think that this is *sometimes* resolved in a way that makes an indicative conditional tantamount to the corresponding material conditional, but not always.

- For example, we might plug the trivial accessibility relation (on which each world only sees itself) into the closeness analysis or the analysis

¹ This example is from Michael McDermott, ‘On the Truth-conditions of Certain “If”-sentences’. However McDermott is not himself a Materialist—he favors a kind of three-valued semantics where conditionals with false antecedents are gappy and the conjunction of something gappy with something true is true.

- In the setting of the closeness analysis, 'If P, Q' is guaranteed to agree with ' $P \supset Q$ ' if the operative accessibility relation is one that not-P worlds never bear to P-and-not-Q worlds.

4. Confidence-theoretic arguments against materialism

- (1) I'm moderately confident that if they went out they went to the movies, but I am very confident that they didn't go out.
- (2) It's unlikely that Smith won big if he won
- (3) It's starting to look like Smith won big if he won

Not just an idiosyncrasy of sentences that contain both 'if' and an attitude verb:

- (4) If they went out they went to the movies.
— You're probably right / I'm pretty confident of that / There's a good chance that they did / That's fairly likely to be true / I'm moderately inclined to agree with what you just said...

A similar argument can be made using desire-like (vs. belief-like) attitudes:

- (5) I'm hoping I've won a blue car if I've won a car